where they remained in authority even after Britain had withdrawn from India.

The era of European colonialism that the Portuguese initiated in India with such violence was not in itself exceptional. What set the Europeans apart was not that their behaviour was any worse than what had gone before but that their imperialism – in essence, the exploitation of one people by another – was applied with an efficiency not seen since the days of the Romans, plus superior firepower, as noted by Hilaire Belloc in a famous couplet:

> *Whatever happens, we have got*
> *The Maxim gun, and they have not.*

So by the time Ludovico di Varthema and his friend Cazazioner arrived at Calicut in January 1505 Portuguese carracks and caravels were busy leapfrogging down the Malabar coast in their quest for the 'five glorious spices' of the Indies: pepper, cinnamon, cloves, nutmeg and mace. But on rounding the tip of the peninsula they found their progress up and along India's eastern coast blocked – by an 18-mile chain of rocks and sandbanks linking the island of Lanka to the Indian mainland.

This was the Iramar Palam, or 'Bridge of Rama', the geomorphic umbilical cord that binds island and subcontinent together whether their respective inhabitants like it or not. To this day the Bridge of Rama offers great scope for one set of believers who claim that satellite images prove it to have been built by Lord Rama ten thousand years ago, and another who call the isthmus Al-jeseer Aadham, or 'Adam's Bridge', and are convinced it was built by the giant Adam after his exile from the Garden of Eden.

Until 1480 the Bridge of Rama was indeed a fairly solid land-bridge, but in that year a particularly ferocious cyclone struck the coast and gouged a trough across the isthmus's